Employee Handbook

Document ID	HR-002
Department	Human Resources
Document type	Handbook
Owner	Chief People Officer
Version	4.1
Status	APPROVED
Effective / last reviewed	2026-03-18
Audience	All employees
Related documents	HR-001, HR-008, HR-013, HR-014

Summary. The Northstar Systems Employee Handbook summarises company structure, working hours, probation, performance cycles, pay, benefits, learning, referrals, grievance and disciplinary routes, the Internal Committee, conduct expectations and exit basics, and points to the detailed policies.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

Welcome to Northstar Systems Private Limited. This handbook gives every employee a single, readable summary of how we work, what we expect, and what you can expect from us. It applies to all employees across Band B1 to B7 in Bengaluru, Mumbai and remote locations. Where a detailed policy exists, this handbook summarises it and names the policy; if the two differ, the detailed policy applies. Legal and regulatory references in this handbook are illustrative and to be verified by Legal before external use.

The handbook is not a contract of employment. Your offer letter and employment agreement set your individual terms. The handbook is reviewed annually by the Chief People Officer and updated on the intranet and in NorthPeople.

2. About Northstar Systems

Northstar Systems is a business-to-business enterprise software and technology services company founded in 2012, with about 500 employees. Our headquarters is Northstar Tower, Whitefield, Bengaluru, which houses about 340 staff. Our second office is in Powai, Mumbai, with about 110 staff, and about 50 colleagues work remotely across India. Our fiscal year runs from 1 April to 31 March.

Our main product is the Northstar Nexus Platform, a workflow and integration platform, with Nexus Connect (API gateway and prebuilt connectors) and Nexus Insight (analytics add-on). Our departments are Human Resources (People Team), Engineering, IT and Security, Operations and Procurement with Finance, and Customer Success with Support. Every employee has an employee ID of the form NS- followed by 5 digits and a corporate email address on the northstar-systems.example domain.

2.1 Bands

Roles are grouped into pay grades called Bands. B1 to B3 are individual contributors and associates, B4 and B5 are senior, lead and manager roles, B6 is director or senior manager, and B7 is vice president and above. Your Band determines approval authority, expense limits, notice period and referral bonus level in several policies.

2.2 Systems you will use

- **NorthPeople**: the HRMS for leave, attendance, appraisals and onboarding tasks.
- **NorthPay**: payroll and expense claims.
- **NorthID**: single sign-on and multi-factor authentication.
- **NorthDesk**: the IT service desk for tickets and access requests; the IT Service Desk is on ext. 4000.
- **NorthLearn**: the learning portal.
- **HR Helpdesk**: hr-helpdesk@northstar-systems.example for any people question.

3. Working Together

3.1 Working hours

The standard working day is 9:30 to 18:30 IST with a 1-hour lunch break. Core collaboration hours are 11:00 to 16:00 IST. Up to 3 late marks per month of up to 30 minutes each are allowed; the 4th late mark in a month is deducted as half-day casual leave. See HR-001 for the full attendance rules.

3.2 Hybrid and remote work

The default arrangement is hybrid: 3 days in the office per week, with Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday as anchor days when teams meet. A fully remote role must be approved by the VP of the function and the Chief People Officer. Fully remote employees receive a work-from-home allowance of INR 1,500 per month, and a one-time home-office setup reimbursement up to INR 15,000 may be claimed once every 3 years. Working from a location other than your registered city for more than 10 working days in a year needs HR and Security approval. See HR-013 and the Remote and Hybrid Work Policy for details.

3.3 Offices and facilities

Offices are open from 8:00 to 20:00 on working days and are accessed with a badge. Visitors must be registered at reception and escorted at all times. Weekend access needs manager approval through a NorthDesk ticket. Emergency assembly points are marked on every floor, and you should know yours.

3.4 Equipment and information security

Company laptops are the only devices allowed for company work. Full-disk encryption and screen lock after 5 minutes are mandatory, and multi-factor authentication through NorthID is required on all corporate systems. A lost or stolen device must be reported to the Security Desk within 1 hour of discovery (ext. 5555 or security@northstar-systems.example) and to the IT Service Desk within 24 hours. New joiners complete mandatory security awareness training within 14 days of joining and an annual refresher thereafter.

3.5 Communication, meetings and feedback

Meetings should have an agenda, a named owner and written notes, and should be scheduled inside core collaboration hours of 11:00 to 16:00 IST so that colleagues in Bengaluru, Mumbai and

remote locations can join. Decisions that affect other teams should be written down in the relevant system, such as a NorthDesk ticket or a project page, rather than left in chat. Managers hold a one-to-one with each team member at least every two weeks, and employees are encouraged to give and ask for feedback throughout the year, not only at review time. Concerns about workload, health or wellbeing may be raised confidentially with the HR Business Partner or through the EAP helpline at any time.

Example: Imran (Band B3, Mumbai) wants to move a weekly customer call to 17:30 IST to suit a client. He should confirm with his manager first, record the change in the team calendar, and make sure the colleagues who attend are comfortable, since 17:30 is outside core hours but still within the standard day ending at 18:30.

4. Joining, Probation and Confirmation

Every new employee has a probation period of 6 months. Probation may be extended once by up to 3 months if performance or conduct needs more time to assess. The reporting manager reviews progress with the employee at least at month 3 and before the end of month 5, and People Team records confirmation in NorthPeople. During probation the notice period is 30 days and Earned Leave cannot yet be used. The detailed joining steps are in HR-005.

Before the joining date is confirmed, background verification must be complete. Offer letters are valid for 7 calendar days from the date of issue, after which the offer lapses unless People Team extends it in writing.

5. Leave and Holidays

The key entitlements per calendar year are summarised below. HR-001 is the authoritative policy.

Type	Entitlement	Note
Casual Leave	8 days	Does not carry forward
Sick Leave	10 days	Medical certificate needed beyond 2 consecutive days; no carry-forward
Earned Leave	18 days, accrued 1.5 days per month	After confirmation; carry-forward max 30 days; encashment on exit up to 15 days
Maternity leave	26 weeks	Illustrative; per applicable law
Paternity leave	10 working days	
Marriage leave	5 working days	Once
Bereavement leave	5 working days	Immediate family

Northstar observes 12 company holidays per calendar year plus 2 floating holidays that you choose from an optional list of 6. Compensatory off for approved work on a weekly off must be used within 60 days. Managers approve or reject leave in NorthPeople within 2 working days; otherwise the request goes to the department head.

6. Performance and Growth

6.1 Review cycles

Northstar runs two performance moments each year. The annual review takes place in April and covers the prior fiscal year. The mid-year check-in takes place in October and is a development conversation rather than a rating event. You set goals with your manager at the start of the fiscal year in NorthPeople and update them as priorities change.

6.2 Ratings and calibration

Ratings are on a 1 to 5 scale: 1 Needs Improvement, 2 Partially Meets, 3 Meets, 4 Exceeds, and 5 Outstanding. Before ratings are released, department heads and HR calibrate them across teams so that standards are applied consistently. Your manager shares your rating in a conversation; you may add your comments in NorthPeople.

6.3 Salary revisions

Salary revisions take effect on 1 May of each year, subject to approved budget, and are paid with the May payroll. Variable pay for the prior fiscal year is paid with the June payroll.

6.4 Performance Improvement Plan

If performance is below expectations, the manager and HR Business Partner may place an employee on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP). A PIP lasts 60 days with fortnightly reviews, has written objectives, and ends with a documented outcome: successful completion, extension in exceptional cases, or separation. A PIP is a support process; employees on a PIP may raise concerns through the grievance route.

6.5 Learning

Every employee has a learning budget of INR 40,000 per fiscal year, used in NorthLearn. Certification fees are reimbursed after you pass the exam. A programme costing more than INR 25,000 carries a 12-month service-retention clawback; if you leave within 12 months of completion, you repay a pro-rata share of the cost. Managers should agree a learning plan with each employee at the April review.

7. Pay and Benefits

7.1 Payroll

Salary is paid monthly and credited on the last working day of the month through NorthPay. The provident fund contribution is 12% of basic pay and gratuity is paid as per applicable law (both illustrative). Payslips are available in NorthPay. Report payroll queries to the Finance Desk (finance@northstar-systems.example) within the same month.

7.2 Benefits summary

- **Group health insurance**: a floater of INR 5,00,000 covering the employee, spouse and up to 2 children. Parents may be added through an optional top-up at the employee's cost.
- **Group term life cover**: 3 times annual fixed pay.
- **Personal accident cover**: INR 10,00,000.
- **Wellness allowance**: INR 12,000 per year; claim with receipts by 31 March.
- **Employee Assistance Programme (EAP)**: a 24x7 confidential counselling helpline, with 3 free sessions per issue.
- **Referral bonus**: INR 25,000 for a referred hire in Band B1 to B4 and INR 50,000 for B5 and above, paid after the referred hire completes 6 months.

Example: Neha (Band B4) refers a friend who joins as a Band B3 engineer. After the friend completes 6 months, Neha receives INR 25,000. If the friend had joined at Band B5, the bonus would be INR 50,000.

7.3 Travel and expenses

All travel needs prior approval in NorthPay, and claims must be filed within 15 calendar days of the trip end. Domestic air travel is economy class. Receipts are mandatory for every expense above INR 500. See HR-004 for caps and procedures.

8. Conduct and Workplace Standards

8.1 Code of conduct

We expect every employee to act with honesty, respect and professionalism. This includes declaring conflicts of interest, protecting confidential information, using company assets properly, and treating colleagues, customers and vendors with courtesy. Discrimination, harassment, bullying, retaliation and falsification of records are not tolerated.

8.2 Acceptable use of technology

Personal use of company devices is limited and must not break policy. Unauthorised software is not allowed. Only AI tools on the Approved AI Tools list may be used, and no Confidential or Restricted data may be entered in external AI tools. Company email is for business purposes, and monitoring is permitted as described in the security policies. Restricted data such as customer production data, employee personal data and credentials must never be shared by personal email.

8.3 Prevention of sexual harassment

Northstar has an Internal Committee (IC) constituted to receive and inquire into complaints of sexual harassment (illustrative; to be verified by Legal). A complaint should be filed within 3 months of the incident; the IC may extend this by 3 months for good reason. The IC completes its inquiry within 90 days. Confidentiality is mandatory for everyone involved, and retaliation against a complainant or witness is prohibited and is itself a disciplinary offence.

8.4 Conflicts of interest, gifts and outside work

Employees must declare any outside employment, directorship or financial interest in a vendor, customer or competitor to their manager and HR Business Partner. Gifts of significant value from vendors must not be accepted, and any gift that could appear to influence a business decision must be reported to the manager. Outside work that conflicts with your role or uses company time or information is not allowed.

9. Grievances and Discipline

9.1 Grievance redressal

If you have a work-related concern, raise it in three levels. Level 1 is your reporting manager, who must resolve it within 5 working days. Level 2 is the HR Business Partner, who has 10 working days. Level 3 is the Grievance Committee, which has 15 working days. You may skip to Level 2 or 3 if your concern involves your manager. Raising a grievance in good faith never leads to retaliation.

9.2 Disciplinary ladder

When conduct falls below standards, the company follows a ladder: a verbal warning, a written warning, a final written warning, and termination. Serious misconduct may justify moving directly to a later step after an inquiry. The employee receives a show-cause notice describing the allegation and must reply within 3 working days. An employee may appeal a disciplinary decision to the Chief People Officer within 7 calendar days of the decision.

Example: A Band B2 employee is found to have shared a customer's production data over personal email. After a show-cause notice and reply within 3 working days, People Team may issue a written warning or a final written warning depending on severity and may also refer the incident to the Security Desk under the security incident process.

10. Leaving Northstar

Notice periods are 30 days during probation, 60 days for confirmed employees, and 90 days for Band B5 and above. A shortfall in notice may be bought out with manager and HR approval at the rate of gross monthly salary divided by 30 per day. Access is disabled by 18:30 IST on the last working day, an exit interview is held within the last 5 working days, and the full and final settlement is paid within 45 days of the last working day. The step-by-step process is in HR-006.

11. Frequently Asked Questions

Can I use Earned Leave in my first year? Only after probation confirmation. Before that you may use Casual Leave and Sick Leave.

What happens if I am late four times in a month? The first 3 late marks (up to 30 minutes each) are within grace; the 4th is deducted as half-day casual leave.

How do I claim the wellness allowance? Submit receipts in NorthPay before 31 March, up to INR 12,000 for the year.

Who approves a fully remote arrangement? The VP of the function and the Chief People Officer.

How soon should I report a lost laptop? To the Security Desk within 1 hour of discovery, and to the IT Service Desk within 24 hours.

When is my variable pay paid? With the June payroll, for the prior fiscal year.

12. Exceptions and Escalation

Exceptions to any people policy need the written approval of the HR Business Partner and the department head, and where the policy owner is another function, of that owner. Any doubt about how to read a policy should go to the HR Helpdesk. Employees who believe a policy is being applied unfairly can use the grievance route above.

13. Related Documents

This handbook should be read with HR-001 (Leave and Attendance Policy), HR-008, HR-013 (hybrid and remote practice), and HR-014. Security obligations are covered in the security policies and the Acceptable Use policy, and expense rules in HR-004.

14. Revision History

Version	Date	Change	Approved by
4.0	2025-04-01	Annual review and addition of EAP and learning clawback	Chief People Officer
4.1	2026-03-18	Updated referral bonus bands, grievance timelines and conduct section	Chief People Officer